'It's easy to walk here,' he said, 'but the distances are long. Selenopolis occupies more than a hundred square kilometres. Let's ride for a bit'.

A moving pavement covered with green plastic strips rushed them through echoing tunnels and spacious caves with walls sparkling in the light of the quartz lamps. The elevator delivered them to the surface. She looked in silence at the enormous lily-shaped tent over a crater that was at least a kilometre in diameter.

'The community of Nations Square,' he told her. 'People of different nationalities who work in Selenopolis come here after work. And there are some tourists. They're walking towards the lake. It's quite an exotic experience to have a swim on the Moon.'

'I'm sure it's better in the river Dnieper when you come to the Earth for your holiday.'

When they looked at the astrodrome, where two spaceships the size of the Ostankino TV tower were pointed into the black void of the universe, she sighed again.

'What are these?'

'Long–range spaceships, Mother. They're planning an expedition to a neighbouring galaxy.'

She screwed up her eyes to look at the rockets where assembly men were busy. They looked quite small from a distance.

She said quietly: 'Why should people go off into the unknown? Why ask for trouble?'

'These are very reliable spaceships, Mother!'

'Wouldn't it make more sense to settle properly on the Moon first, and then on the planets in the solar system, before going further?'

It was now his turn to sigh. 'You may be right, but…'

'But what?'

'How do I know?'

He longed to tell her about the flight he was longing for and about how nervous he had been when confronted by the selection commission. But he checked himself. It was their last meeting before his departure, so why spoil it?



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